vote base," says a senior BJP leader. A veteran politician from western Maharashtra confirms this, saying that unlike Shinde's men, who seem to lack the support of the Sena rank-and-file, NCP defectors are on a stronger wicket, thanks to their grassroots network of cooperative institutions, which binds the rural and semi-rural voters to them.

A SAVVY MOVE

The NCP faction's arrival bolsters the BJP's plans in more ways than one. It not only boosts the BJP-led NDA's chances in NCP strongholds like the districts of western Maharashtra, along with the latter's pocketboroughs in Marathwada, north Maharashtra and Vidarbha region, but also checkmates the rising ambitions of CM Shinde and his Sena cohort. Indeed, it may even have ramifications for the national opposition alliance—Pawar Sr was considered the anchor that would bring diverse forces together. With his own house now in tumult, the next meeting of the alliance leaders—scheduled for July 13-14 in Bengaluru—now seems almost an impossibility.

The success of the NCP coup will also embolden the saffron party to try the same in other states. Even as the storm in Maharashtra was peaking, the media was abuzz with rumours of a split in the Janata Dal (United) in Bihar. Former deputy CM Sushil Kumar Modi of the BJP has already made a prediction on those lines. The Bihar assembly numbers are such that they may not be able to clinch the deal in the near future, but there's no doubt it has added to the worry lines on CM Nitish Kumar's visage. So much so that the CM has apparently been meeting party legislators and parliamentarians individually in Patna. In private, BJP leaders admit the urgency to bring in the NCP faction was dictated by the fear that the party may not be able to match the 2019 Lok Sabha tally from the state in 2024. Maharashtra, with its 48 seats being the second highest of any state after Uttar Pradesh, is crucial in the BJP's plans to secure a third term at the Centre. The BJP-Sena (undivided) alliance had won 41 of those.

The Congress victory in the March bypolls in BJP bastion Kasba Peth in Pune also seems to have rattled the party, who saw it as an indication of the core support of the Congress-Sena (Uddhav faction)-NCP increasing. Hence the haste in cleaving open the NCP and splintering the opposition. A senior politician from western Maharashtra points to another reason why it was essential to "destroy the unity of the MVA, a rainbow alliance of diverse parties on an anti-BJP platform"—the risk that the template would be replicated in other states. "This will sound the death knell for the MVA," he claimed. The defections may also erode the voters' confidence in the MVA's ability to keep its flock together.



MANDAR DEODHAR

THE NCP COUP'S SUCCESS MAY EMBOLDEN THE SAFFRON PARTY TO TRY THE SAME IN OTHER STATES. EVEN AS THE STORM IN MAHARASHTRA WAS PEAKING, THE MEDIA WAS ABUZZ WITH RUMOURS OF A SPLIT IN THE JD(U) IN BIHAR

PAWAR VS PAWAR

Ajit's rebellion comes after months of speculation about his moves. It is learnt that during a visit to Delhi for the marriage of an NCP legislator's daughter, he was served an ultimatum by a senior BJP leader whom he met on the sly. This was followed by Shinde and Fadnavis making a whistle-stop trip to Delhi to consult senior BJP leaders after which the decision to induct Ajit and his men in the government was taken.

On July 5, the rival NCP camps